

A 19-inch monitor represents the best possible price point for someone interested in multimedia, but wanting something larger than a 17-inch panel. The cost difference between an entry level 17- and 19-inch monitor is as low as Rs 3,000, and as you'll see a bit later, there were 17-inch panels that cost much more than many 19-inch ones. Once you go above 19-inches, prices go haywire as you approach the realm of 20.1-inch and above panels.

A 20.1 inch LCD will cost at least Rs 4,500 more than a 19-inch, though there is hardly a difference in resolution between the two (note that 17-inch and 19-inch monitors have the same native resolution). Also most of the high-end panels—S-IPS and PVA/MVA—fall in the 20.1-inch and above size categories—monitors sporting these panels will be costlier still.

If your usage is for multimedia—games, movies, etc.—skip the 17-inch category and invest that extra bit in a 19-inch screen; the sheer visual real-estate will be worth the extra cash. In fact, a 19-inch monitor will benefit even regular office applications—Excel, most notably.



AOC 1975
Sturdy, wallet friendly performer

Feature Rich, But Not Fancy-free

This category had the biggest price range, so it was natural to expect a lot of different features. If we were to choose a looker, it'd have to be the ASUS PG191—superb build quality, and a very classy looking buffed metal stand with a piano-black bezel topping things off. A pity the thing weighed about as much as a hippo. The stand also integrates a dedicated speaker driver unit, just behind the panel mount. Sound quality was very good—not tinny as one would expect from integrated speakers. Add to the kitty a good 1.3 Megapixel webcam that's better than the generic webcams in the market. Beauty doesn't come cheap though, and the TN panel-based PG191 costs Rs 28,000, and has touch-sensitive menu controls.

How We Tested

The Test Bench

Processor: Core 2 Extreme X6800
Graphics Card: Geforce 8800GTX
OS: Windows XP Professional SP2

All tests were performed at the LCD's native resolution, and monitors have been categorised according to panel size.

We calibrated all the LCD's using Display Mate Video Edition calibration suite. Once calibrated, no adjustments followed.

Display Test Software

1. DisplayMate Video Edition
2. PassMark's MonTest

Real World Tests

1. Animated Video file (HD 1080p clips)
2. HD movie clips
3. Game tests
 - a. Oblivion (game played in three different environments—dungeon, outdoor and planes of Oblivion)
 - b. F.E.A.R (fixed length demo)

Parameters Tested

DisplayMate Video Edition

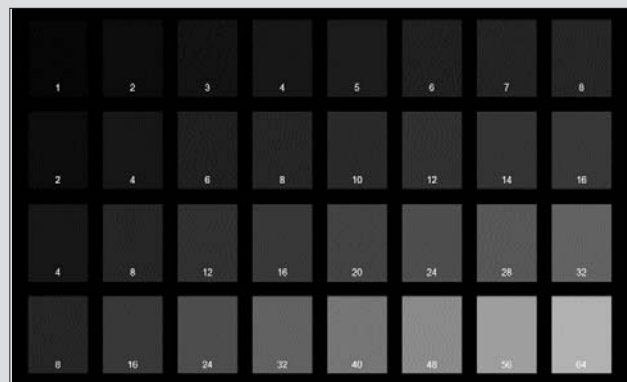
1. Sharpness and Resolution Tests
2. Pixel Resolution Tests
3. Colour and Greyscale Tests
4. Miscellaneous Tests

PassMark's MonTest

Although most of the MonTest suite is similar to DisplayMate, there was one important test that it adds—the Pixel Persistence test. Here, the monitors' ability to draw and redraw a pixel is checked, which basically gives us an idea to its response time, and hence its suitability for gaming and movie-watching.

Multimedia Tests

The movie clips give as an idea of the test subjects' suitability to multimedia, by testing and judging on parameters like



The Gray Card test in DisplayMate



Reverse Text Test - DisplayMate

brightness levels, contrast, pixel response, and colour rendition.

The Game Tests allow us to ascertain the suitability of the display to playing games. We play identical timed benchmarks across all the screens and look for input lag, ghosting, brightness and contrast, rendition of special effects like HDR, explosions, bullet time effects (in F.E.A.R). Oblivion provides us a good opportunity to judge these monitors rendition of outdoor scenery as the game has one of the best environments (graphically) in the business.